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This approach reinforces several of GitLab's values.

- Efficiency: We can provide a better candidate experience and hire faster since neither candidate nor interviewer must travel.
- Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging: We create a level playing field for all candidates by allowing them to interview from a space where they are comfortable.

What to do after you hire a remote worker

Invest in onboarding

When hiring in an all-remote organization, it is critical to onboard new team members well. You have to give new hires the information they need to do their jobs, and you have to empower them to think remotely. Remote onboarding relies heavily on documentation, anticipating the needs of new team members, and a dedication to continuously improving the process based on feedback.

Onboarding is a continuous process during a team member's first year. Investing upfront in your onboarding process will yield long-term benefits:

1. Sets clear expectations
1. Reduces new-hire anxiety
1. Increases productivity more quickly
1. Better team member retention

Companies that invest in onboarding report 54% more productivity from new hires. Studies show that 87% of team members are less likely to leave a company when they feel engaged.

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We are so convinced in the power of onboarding well that we've created a Complete Guide to Remote Onboarding for New Hires. To help new hires focus on three key onboarding dimensions--organizational, technical, and social--we assign a mentor or onboarding buddy.

Assign a mentor or onboarding buddy

To help prevent New Job Anxiety and aid onboarding and the adjustment to an all-remote culture, new team members are assigned an onboarding buddy.

A mentor or onboarding buddy is a friendly point of contact for a new team member. This individual sets the example for building relationships and models how to communicate in a

variety of ways, such as video calls, check-ins on Slack, and coffee chats.

Practice informal communication

Knowing that remote workers can experience loneliness or burnout, it's important to prioritize relationship-building through regular social interactions. Remote workers can socialize using informal communication.

Perform regular check-ins

Model good informal communication practices with new hires by scheduling regular check-ins throughout their first few months. These can be a blend of formal and informal meetings used to gauge how they are progressing in their onboarding and to ensure they are acclimating to the work, team, company, and culture.

Global hiring best practices

GitLab hires globally because we envision a world where talented, driven individuals seek employment and find roles based on business needs rather than geographic location. In our 10+ years of global hiring, we have significantly developed our best practices. Here are a few things to keep in mind; please see the hiring section of our handbook for more in-depth coverage.

Where do you not hire?

GitLab is often asked about which countries we hire in, and why. The simplest answer is that we continually strive to have the widest possible global hiring coverage, limited only by logistics and legality.

Each country has unique and complex rules, laws and regulations, which can affect how we conduct business, as well as the employability of the citizens in those countries. For companies that are just beginning to work remotely and seek to expand globally, the process of setting up entities in compliance with each country's requirements is a lengthy one.

We are growing rapidly and continuously expanding our hiring capabilities in other geographies. In countries listed in our `entitymapper.yml` file that don't have `contractor: true`, we have a payroll and can employ people directly. In all other listed countries, we can hire people as a contractor.

Learn more at our [Country Hiring Guidelines](#) section in the [Employment Solutions \(International Expansion & Relocations\)](#) handbook page.

Handling local regulations, risks, entities, etc

Rather than attempting to incorporate in every country where an all-remote company has even a single employee, organizations must weigh the benefits of creating a legal entity with other options. There are four means of engagement with GitLab. These are commonly used arrangements that can be considered by other all-remote companies.

- GitLab Entity: Individuals can be employed directly with GitLab Inc, BV, LTD, GmbH, PTY,

Federal.

- Professional Employer Organization (PEO): In select countries where GitLab does not have an entity, we hire professional employment organizations to serve as the employer of record (EOR) in order to facilitate payments.
- C2C (Contractor): A corp to corp arrangement, whereby a corporation or LLC invoices GitLab BV for GitLab related work.
- IND (Contractor): By far the most widely applicable. The individual contractor arrangement can be used in countries where GitLab is hiring, yet does not have an entity or PEO agreement in place. This allows an individual to invoice GitLab BV as an individual or via their own company with no partners.

Learn more about employee types and hiring partners across countries in the [Contracts, Probation Periods & PIAA handbook page](#).

It is not always practical to understand the nuances of local regulations in-house. Wherever GitLab has an entity or contractor, we have external counsel to advise and ensure that we are compliant.

In countries where GitLab utilizes a professional employer organization (PEO), counsel within the PEO advises us to ensure hiring compliance.

Deciding between entity and PEO

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Generally speaking, it becomes feasible to consider creating an entity within a country once a company reaches 20+ team members in that country. While total costs vary significantly from country to country, creating an entity within a country can cost as little as a few hundred dollars to tens of thousands of dollars.

A company must also hire skilled team members to oversee compliance with local taxes, laws, benefits, etc. in each country where there is an entity.

For countries where a company is not already incorporated or has a local entity, consider the below as a guide.

1. Fewer than 5 team members: Utilize a contractor arrangement
1. Between 5 and 20 team members: Leverage a Professional Employer Organization (PEO)
1. 20+ team members: Consider establishing a local entity

Impact of nonuniform hiring on employee experience

Beyond the administrative challenges associated with using various vehicles (entities, PEOs, contractors, etc.) to hire team members, companies should be proactive in recognizing how this will impact culture and morale.

While GitLab believes that there are far more pros than cons to hiring globally · creating a geographically diverse team, finding the world's best talent, hiring in underserved areas and connecting with people from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds · it's wise to evaluate how

nonuniform hiring mechanisms may conflict with a company's values.

When leveraging a third-party to hire, it is difficult to ensure that they will treat your employees how you would ideally like to see them treated. Third-party companies are under no obligation to understand or implement your values.

It is imperative that the hiring team communicate this in advance, ideally during the interview phase, to manage expectations of employees who are hired by a third-party firm that may not always act in accordance to your values.

Moreover, one should aim to leverage a single Professional Employer Organization (PEO) over the long term. Switching PEOs is disruptive to team members and creates mental and administrative burden. A growing company should pay particular attention to feedback from employees who rely on PEOs, and plan beyond current hiring needs.

Is there a single PEO that covers the globe?

This is a common question from remote-first and all-remote companies who are understandably interested in streamlining the process of hiring talented team members from an array of countries. The short answer, for now, is "no."

Some PEOs serve an array of regions, but offer varying levels of service and disparate experiences from country to country. Seek out advice where possible to gather country-level feedback.

Remote is a new company that intends to tackle this challenge over time.

> Remote is working on solving global employment by allowing companies to employ people locally through Remote. That is, full employment local to each and every employee, but a single invoice for the employer. Remote manages payroll, benefits, and compliance, according to the standards of the employer.

Be intentional about due diligence when vetting PEOs. Some firms advertise global reach, but do not offer high-touch, reliable end-to-end service in every country. Instead, they leverage third-parties themselves in various countries, creating yet another layer in the process that may negatively impact employee experience.

Local Sourcers: what they are and why you need them

Even when the world is your talent pool, there will be niche roles requiring a specialized applicant search. To that end, GitLab built a Sourcing team tasked with finding the best talent and nurturing the candidate pipeline · a strategy any company can implement.

While GitLab is location-agnostic, we ensure that we have local Sourcers based in every macro-region (e.g., Americas, APAC, and EMEA) poised to share their market expertise and leverage our presence in these territories.

Our sourcing effort is extremely important for bringing diverse talent onboard. Our Sourcers regularly network with recruiters and business verticals so they can quickly tap into real-time knowledge of specific markets when a niche position comes available.

Driven by our Collaboration value, we organize source-a-thons, which become a place for everyone to share market insights and contribute to hiring. These sessions are extremely productive as they help Sourcers better partner with their hiring managers and calibrate expectations. You can learn more about how GitLab's Sourcing team operates here.

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/how-to-work-remote-first.md

What is a forcing function?

A forcing function is any task, activity, or event that forces you to take action and produce a result. This term comes from interaction design, where it refers to a constraint that shapes behavior.

Transitioning to remote is challenging but worthwhile. For many leaders, the question of "How do we do it?" is a giant one. Whether it's entirely disconnecting from offices and going all-remote, or attempting to create a level playing field for in-office and remote team members in a hybrid-remote arrangement, leaders should consider using some of key forcing functions outlined below to ensure a commitment to remote-first practices. At GitLab, we use forcing functions to empower and encourage team members to use best practices and to reinforce our values.

How can I use a forcing function to work remote-first?

Use the content from our presentation at GitLab Culture Open House 2020, which details tactical, actionable steps to send a clear message that leadership is serious about implementing remote-first in the organization. There are many forcing functions you can choose to implement that will help encourage remote-first mindsets and behavior.

Expire your Slack or Teams messages after 90 days

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When you work synchronously, tools like Slack or Microsoft Teams enable conversations that can go on for months. The upside is the potential for immediate replies. The downsides are numerous. A never-ending strand of red bubbles (unread notifications) can take a toll on one's mental health, and completely destroys a human's ability to find a state of flow.

Letting Slack pings dictate your working life is a recipe for burnout. It's also a terrible way to work. Messages are siloed outside of public channels, so it's impossible for others to transparently see what others are working on.

To solve for this, only pay for a chat plan that retains messages for 90 days or less. If your team knows that they'll never be able to query a message thread for context on a project, they will not use the tool for work. Instead, they'll be forced to start, discuss, and complete work in the place where it should end up. At GitLab (the company), this is GitLab (the product).

This not only forces work to happen in the open, where more people can provide feedback as they work to see each other succeed, but it's also a far more inclusive way to work.

{{< youtube "IU2nTj6NSIQ?" >}}

In the video above, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the topic of scaling culture during an interview with Stuart Miniman, host of theCUBE and GM of Content at SiliconANGLE Media. A portion is transcribed below.

> Remote is much better for your mental health and sanity than other settings, and it's because it forces you to work asynchronously. At GitLab, we have people spread across 65 countries, so almost every time zone is covered. But, that also means that someone on your team is likely in a vastly different timezone. In fact, they may be asleep the entire time you're up working.

>

> With an asynchronous mindset, it enables all of us to take a step back and assume that whatever we're doing is done with no one else online. It removes the burden of a nonstop string of messages where you're expected to respond to things immediately.

>

> From a mental health standpoint, when you have an entire company that embraces that, we're all given a little more breathing room to do really deep work that requires long periods of uninterrupted time.

>

> As a society, we're getting close to a tipping point where people are at their limit on how many more messages, or emails, or seemingly urgent pings they can manage while also doing their job well. We may be a bit ahead of the curve on that, but my hope is that the industry at large embraces asynchronous communication, and allows their people more time to actually do the work they were hired to do

Offices are simply venues to work remotely from

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</div>
<div data-bbox="114 768 896 835" data-label="Text">
<p>The only way a hybrid-remote setting is beloved long-term is if leadership treats everyone as remote, regardless of where they are. The office must simply be regarded as another single-person dwelling. It's simply a place one goes to work remotely, treated the same as a home or apartment.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 851 900 902" data-label="Text">
<p>The office must become a physical embodiment of a carefully curated remote culture, not vice-versa. The culture cannot be tied to a physical location, or else those outside of the office will always feel deprioritized · like outsiders that don't belong.</p>
</div>

Use chat tools strictly for informal communication

When your chat tool(s) expire messages after 90 days, it renders it useful for only one primary thing: informal communication. This is intentional.

In all-remote settings, informal communication must be structured. The beauty of using a tool like Slack purely for this purpose is it enables even more genuine and intimate conversations than you'd typically experience in a colocated space.

For example, GitLab has group, location, section, values feed, and social group channels. This enables people to openly converse about informal topics such as parenting, fitness, travel, music, and mental health.

Using GitLab for remote collaboration

Because we do not use a chat tool such as Slack for work, we need a tool that's built for remote collaboration. GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at GitLab's remote team solutions page.

Implement discretionary bonuses for exemplifying values

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Intentional companies can surface their values during onboarding, but you should consider how this will be reinforced on an ongoing basis. Forcing your company to honor and respect remote employees, and not forget their presence and value, can be done very simply: implement discretionary bonuses, where the only mechanism for earning one is to be nominated by another team member for living out one or more of the company values.

These bonuses aren't about sales targets, added revenue, or working late. They are purely about values. When you create an incentive program that recognizes someone publicly for exemplifying a value, this serves as a constant reminder to all that values have meaning, and they should be lived out daily · even when (and especially when) it's difficult.

At GitLab, we celebrate each discretionary bonus which is earned and bestowed, with a few sentences explaining which value(s) were exemplified in a public Slack channel. This gives context to how a value can be lived out, and serves as a model for everyone else to replicate.

When you give the bonus and celebrate the bonus in Slack, it also serves as a reminder to in-office colleagues that values can be lived out by team members you don't see. This has long-tail benefits as well, like removing barriers for praise, promotion, and career growth for remote team members.

Use technology to remind people to take time off

Remote teams have an easier time speaking freely about travel. Because they're remote, they're autonomous by default, and location is decoupled from output. In-office teams face stigmas related to conversing about vacations in the office.

An easy way to force this toxic cloud of taboo out of your team is to use a digital program to remind team members to take time off. At GitLab, we work with Time Off by Deel in conjunction with Workday to create an opt-in program which sends a direct message on the first working day of each month asking the individual to consider what time they plan on taking this month to rest and recharge. It also gives permission to the team member to directly confront their manager if they feel as if they cannot possibly take time off.

GitLab's verbiage is below.

> Hi there! Have you thought about what days you may take off this month? ... We want to make sure you stay healthy! If you feel like you can't reasonably take time off, feel welcome to add this note to your next 1:1 with your manager and discuss further. Learn more about paid time off at GitLab: <https://handbook.gitlab.com/handbook/people-group/paid-time-off/>

This remote-first behavior triggers a healthy reminder for people to chat about travel or spending time in their community · informal communication that is centered about prioritizing mental health.

Everyone must use their own webcam (no hybrid calls)

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Imagine this scenario. You're in a conference room with five others, being joined by a group of five remote team members in a video call.

Those in the office are inclined to use the office camera, dialing in as a single participant with five heads and voices. This creates an unlevel playing field, where the remote team members are immediately seen as inferior, and are given a substandard call experience. (We've detailed why hybrid calls are horrible in the Communication section of the GitLab handbook.)

The forcing function here is to mandate that everyone, at all times, use their own webcam. This would mean that each individual in the aforementioned conference room would need to open their own laptop and join. This would feel remarkably awkward to those in the room, which is precisely the point. The next logical question is the intended conclusion: why did everyone in the office bother commuting?

The call can be taken from anywhere, and your remote team will function more cohesively if you simply close the office.

Decline all meetings which lack an agenda

Every meeting should be a review of a concrete proposal, and only called when it will lead to a more efficient outcome than would be possible asynchronously.

If you get a meeting invite without an agenda · and it's not an informal coffee chat · leaders

should empower their teams to decline. This will force team members to think long and hard on whether a meeting is necessary, and the burden of adding an agenda shows those who are invited that the organizer is proactively thinking through the meeting's purpose.

It's also respectful, as it allows those in different time zones the opportunity to contribute questions and topics in advance, asynchronously.

Mandate meeting organizers document all takeaways

Put simply, meeting organizers are on the hook for documentation. They can either document themselves, transcribe with a tool like Otter, or line up a dedicated scribe for the call.

It's not enough to merely document the call. The meeting organizer must also contextualize key takeaways using low-context communication and add to relevant handbook pages. This ensures that decisions and progress are made public to the entire team.

This added burden forces team members to consider approaching work asynchronously first. While this may seem absurd, it's a key example of going slow to go fast.

{{< youtube "3HHyjAV3hYE?start=581" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and Gabe (Senior Product Manager, GitLab) talk on the topic of going slow to go fast, as well as the importance of a "handbook-first" approach to company-wide documentation.

> I think documentation has to be instilled as a value. It has to start there, and the whole leadership team in an organization has to be onboard.

>

> All of leadership needs to understand the importance of documentation · not just with lip service. A true, genuine understanding of its value. If they truly understand the value of it, they'll emanate that to their direct reports.

>

> For companies looking to transition to fully remote, a helpful step for leadership is to say: "OK, we're going to be remote-first as a start." This means that a company in transition would optimize everything in its physical office space to be remote-first. Instead of optimizing conference rooms with lots of tables, for instance, you have each employee sit in their own office and wear headsets all day. This is how you prevent remote employees from feeling disconnected and isolated.

>

> This is going slow to go fast. Lots of energy up front · you go slow · but that accelerates things dramatically a year or so down the road. · Gabe W., Senior Product Manager, GitLab

Make the executive team remote

{{< youtube "SP7u0gYCHiY?start=608" >}}

In the video above, Darren Murph, Head of Remote at GitLab sits down with Jeff Frick for a Digital CUBE Conversation about the way the global Covid-19 crisis is affecting the way people work, and work from home. Discover more in GitLab's Remote Work playlist.

The quickest way to send the clearest signal that remote is the future is to start at the top of the organizational chart. Remove execs from the office, and you'll quickly figure out what gaps you need to fill with tools and process.

If you force the executive team to work remotely for a meaningful amount of time (over one month, in most cases), you'll discover communication gaps, as well as voids in tooling and process.

While each company is unique, this approach ensures that you develop a priority list of elements to address in going remote which are relevant to your firm.

Remove company-wide "set working hours"

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So long as your company adheres · even if unofficially · to set working hours, you'll be biased towards candidates who are in your preferred time zone.

The only way to remove that bias and open your company to a truly global and diverse workforce is to destroy the epicenter of power as it relates to working hours.

This also enables your workforce to design their work around their life, empowering them to be managers of one. This is a more inclusive and healthier way of working.

If it's not in the handbook, it doesn't exist

Your goal should be to answer everything with a link. If a team member asks you a question that you can't answer with a link, you should work according to company values to generate an answer, and immediately document that answer in the appropriate place in the handbook. This ensures that anyone who has the same inquiry at any point in the future will not have to impede on anyone's time to find the answer.

Read more about this forcing function in GitLab's guide to adopting a self-service and self-learning mentality.

{{< youtube "I-XQfP-NfpU?start=376" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and two co-founders at Yac discuss the significance of relying on a company handbook as the single source of truth.

> "GitLab's founders made a fundamental decision early on to work handbook-first to document everything about the company. Everyone who has joined since benefits from that initial step.

>

> In my onboarding process, I simply read and ingested what was already documented. There was no ambiguity. A few weeks in, if I had a question, I simply queried the handbook to find an answer.

>

> At a conventional company, you have to tap someone on the shoulder, interrupt their day, and ask them to walk you through it. At scale, the ability to query a handbook for solutions

creates massive efficiencies.

>

> You have hundreds or thousands of people that are able to self-service and find the answers they need when they need them, regardless of what time zone they're in, instead of having to bother someone to find something that's already written down." · Darren M., Head of Remote at GitLab

Reconsider what your values reinforce

Values drive action. If your values are structured to encourage conventional colocated workplace norms (such as consensus gathering, or recurring meetings with in-person teams), rewrite them.

Feel welcome to study GitLab's values, and learn more on how this collection contributes to an all-remote environment.

What are some tips for working remote-first?

We've gathered our top 5 tips for successful remote working:

1. Create a dedicated workspace (focus)
1. Separate work from life (avoid burnout)
1. Keep engaging with people (avoid loneliness)
1. Respect routine, but experiment with change (balance)
1. Be flexible and roll with the changes (iteration)

What are some challenges of working remote-first?

Despite having many advantages, all-remote work can have some downsides.

{{< youtube "CwOLAKSdlfs" >}}

In this video, GitLab Director of Technical Evangelism Priyanka Sharma discusses pros and cons of remote working with a panel of experts from TFiR, Arm and ISG Research.

You can do a deep dive on remote-work challenges and solutions here.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: How to use Forcing Functions to Work Remote-First

Anyone can test their knowledge on How to use forcing functions to work remote-first by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

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[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/hybrid-remote.md

On this page, we're detailing the primary differences between all-remote and other forms of remote working.

What does hybrid-remote mean?

{{< youtube "HhlqwJsNyM" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Anna-Karin (Because Mondays) discuss a number of challenges and solutions related to remote work, transitioning a company to remote, working asynchronously, and defaulting to documentation.

Hybrid-remote (which can be referred to as part-remote), is different than all-remote. In an all-remote company, there is no single headquarters, and each team member is free to live and work in any place they choose. Everyone, including executives, is remote, as there are no offices to come to.

Hybrid-remote is currently more common than all-remote, as it is easier for large, established companies to implement. In a hybrid-remote scenario, there is one or more offices where a subset of the company commutes to each day · working physically in the same space · paired with a subset of the company that works remotely.

These institutions are primarily colocated, but allow remote work. The day-to-day workplace experience for remote-by-default individuals is vastly different (and typically inferior) in a hybrid organization vs. an all-remote organization.

{{< youtube "QFbrPR0jAYs?start=3" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij, chats with Maren Kate, founder at AVRA Talent Partners.

In discussing the decision to go all-remote at GitLab, Sid shares the following.

> For us, it was really important that people didn't have to come to the office to get information necessary for career opportunities.

>

> From very early on, we started writing things down. During Y Combinator, they told us "Look, remote work is for engineering, but not finance, marketing, or sales."

>

> So, we got an office. People got hired, they came there, but after a few days they stopped showing up.

>

> [Coming to the office] wasn't needed. They weren't getting any extra information. They were on Slack, on Zoom, in Google Docs, in GitLab pages, in GitLab Issues, in GitLab merge requests · they didn't need to be there.

>

> It's not that people like their commute; it's just that people don't want to miss out. If you make sure that people don't miss out, you can be remote, too. It takes a lot of effort and focus to make sure all conversations are captured appropriately and that everything is documented. - GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij

Why do employees want hybrid-remote work?

Employees who want a blend of in-person and working may be attracted to the hybrid-remote working option for many reasons:

- They may want to have regular "face time" with leadership, if senior leaders are based in the office.
- They may prefer to have in-person whiteboarding or collaboration sessions with creative teammates.
- It may be a pleasant way to maintain variety in their weekly routine.
- Or, in an office-first company, hybrid-remote may be the closest option available to working all-remote.

Read more about the ten models of remote and hybrid teams.

Variations of the hybrid model

Remote and hybrid work come in a variety of forms, which are continually evolving and growing in popularity.

- The office-centric hybrid approach

An office-centric hybrid organization looks like a team that is not changing how it works. Synchronous, undocumented meetings and disconnected whiteboards are still hallmarks of collaboration. People are expected in the office for a predetermined number of days per week, though the reasoning is flimsy at best (e.g. "We like seeing people around.").

This approach roughly aligns with GitLab's definitions of remote time / remote exceptions.

Leadership supports this model by continuing to do what it has always done.

- The flexible hybrid approach

This variation is marked by some initiative to introduce new tools and technologies into the workforce which are designed for distributed collaboration and contribution. Real estate exists for those who wish to work in the office, but there is not necessarily a set amount of forced days-in-office.

This approach roughly aligns with GitLab's definitions of remote time / remote allowed / remote days.

Leadership supports this model by creating policies and approving new tools and technology to allow testing new flexibilities.

- The remote-friendly hybrid

Remote-friendly is marked by a wider acceptance of global distribution of people. Tools are in place that make it easy to work remotely, and processes are remote-friendly by design. Offices exist but serve more as complementary to remote work as opposed to being the first place people go to work.

This approach roughly aligns with GitLab's definitions of remote allowed / remote first.

For leadership to support remote-friendly operation, remote work is supported at all levels of the company, with leaders modeling this behavior by working remotely on certain days themselves.

Being remote-friendly implies that the company also allows people to work asynchronously without forcing set working hours.

This workplace approach has also been called "fully flexible" by Lyft.

- The virtual first approach

Virtual first is the same as remote first, with digital-first and distributed-first also synonymous. This is marked by a deliberate, org-wide approach to pressure test culture, values, and workflows to guarantee that every element serves first the distributed workforce and not the vestiges of office-first workflows.

In the virtual-first workplace, everyone from top to bottom (and especially leadership) should ideally be out of the office.

In virtual-first, the company defaults to asynchronous work.

What is the difference between remote and hybrid working?

In an all-remote workplace, remote is the default, not the exception. Everything from how meetings are handled to onboarding new hires is structured through a remote lens.

Hybrid-remote generally requires more effort to execute well than all-located or all-remote given the two-tier work environment.

Some hybrid-remote arrangements may involve regular commutes to the office, though not daily commutes. For example, a remote employee in a hybrid-remote organization may travel to an office one week each month for regularly scheduled in-person interactions, while working from a location of their choosing the rest of the month.

What to consider when going hybrid-remote

For some firms, shifting to all-remote may be impractical or impossible. Hybrid-remote is a popular alternative, but one that should be embraced with great deliberation, care, and intentionality. Hybrid-remote generally requires more effort to execute well than all-colocated or all-remote given the two-tier work environment. Below are specific areas to consider and plan for to ensure the smoothest operation.

Only some days in the office

Companies which mandate or encourage 1 or more days per week in-office should be mindful of three important factors.

1. This inhibits team members from considering drastically different living locales, as they still need to be within a commutable distance to an office.

1. This prevents a company's sourcing and talent acquisition teams from operating differently compared to all-colocated. New hires will still need to relocate to the general office area, limiting your talent pool.

1. This will make the process of shifting to remote-first workflows more difficult, as the office will serve as a crutch to collaboration.

Informal meetings

Informal (or unscheduled and unplanned) meetings in an office can be highly disruptive to hybrid-remote teams. While it may feel efficient to ask someone you see in a hallway for a few minutes of their time, this typically creates disruption in the day of the person you're hailing and leads to undocumented progress. Said progress is invisible to those outside of the office as well as others in the office who are not invited to the meeting, which works against the remote-first practice of documenting all work so that others in the organization can contribute.

Leaders should reinforce a particular rigor on documenting takeaways following informal meetings so that context is agreed-upon, it is visible to others regardless of their location, and miscommunication and gossip is minimized.

Redesigned spaces for individual hybrid-remote meeting rooms

Hybrid calls are suboptimal for remote attendees. Leaders transitioning to hybrid-remote should consider redesigning existing office space to optimize for individual workspaces and individual meeting rooms. This reinforces that the office is simply another venue to work remotely from.

Eliminating conference rooms serves as a forcing function to ensure collaboration is accessible to all and removes the temptation to have in-office team members gather around a single camera for a video call with remote attendees.

Leaders may consider keeping one or two large spaces to be reserved for team onsite, where entire teams or sub-teams will intentionally travel on specific dates to meet in person (e.g. fiscal year planning, team bonding, etc.). It's important to still document outcomes from these gatherings and ensure that 100% of the team is included.

Zoom is creating in-office videocall solutions which detect individual faces in a shared room and pull them into panes for remote colleagues. As hybrid-remote becomes increasingly popular

post-COVID, we anticipate solutions like these will better equalize the field of collaboration.

Agendas upfront

The most functional hybrid organizations operate remote-first. This ensures that business continues even if 100% of the workforce opts to work remotely, outside of the office, on any given day. A key part of reinforcing this mindset is a mandate that all work meetings have an upfront agenda.

Practically speaking, this means that all in-office meeting invites have a shared agenda document attached, so that others can read, learn, and contribute regardless of their location (or even if they're awake and available during the meeting time). This process ensures that a Live Doc Meeting procedure happens even for onsite meetings.

This is critical for process continuity regardless of where a team member is. In a hybrid organization, you will have team members who conduct onsite meetings some days, and remote meetings on other days. It's vital that the process of those meetings are the same; it's merely the physical position of a team member that changes.

Coffee chats should be indiscriminate of location

Coffee chats are an excellent way to broaden one's perspective and meet new people from across the organization. Hybrid organizations should take care to not enable selective coffee chat pairing based on who is onsite and who is remote, as it signals a two-tier work environment.

Record important conversations

The proximity of people in an office makes hallway, watercooler, and ad hoc conversations appealing. Leaders in hybrid-remote settings should reinforce the importance of using one's smartphone as a recording device to capture important, non-confidential work-related conversations, so that takeaways are more transparently shared with those outside of the office and misinterpretations are minimized.

Leadership's place in the office

The best place for leaders and executives to be in a hybrid-remote environment is outside of the office.

1. This prevents remote team members from a perceived lack of "face time" with executives.
1. This prevents senior leadership from conducting their work in ways which are counter to remote-first principles.
1. This prevents cognitive dissonance from leadership on what tools, technologies, and training need to be prioritized to support remote-first workflows.
1. This prevents team members from coming to the office to rub shoulders with executives.
1. This reinforces that the office is no longer the epicenter of power or decision making.

Ad hoc social events

It's understandable for team members to long for social gatherings in and around office settings. Structuring informal communication is vital in a remote setting, and some companies

may choose to repurpose some of their office space to accommodate groups and gatherings. Libraries, fitness centers, game rooms, and music studios (among others) could be created to facilitate social gatherings for those who are onsite on any given day.

Leaders who enable this should be mindful of the following.

1. It's important to budget for travel to include remote team members in onsite social events.
1. Work should not happen in social rooms, as it hinders transparency and creates dysfunction through the formation of communication silos.

Equitable benefits and perks

Leaders should carefully evaluate spoken and unspoken perks of the office, and seek to extend equal benefits to those outside of the office. For example, access to an onsite daycare and fitness center would demand a childcare and fitness credit for those who are remote by default. This becomes particularly tricky for team members who are onsite some days of the week, and offsite others, unless the credits are extended to all.

Authenticity in the interview process

When growing your team in a hybrid-remote setting, be sure to present an authentic picture of your culture to all candidates. If you interview a candidate in your office when they'll primarily be working remotely, they're unlikely to get a full understanding of what the employee experience will be like once they're on board. This can lead to engagement and retention issues. During the interview process, focus on the aspects of your culture that are universal to all team members, no matter where their work gets done.

Expect rapid iteration

Hybrid-remote organizations may see high office utilization in the earliest days of a transition, as people flock to the familiar. However, as remote-first workflows are implemented and people relocate or optimize their life for something greater than a commutable distance to an office, it's possible that more space will go unused.

While this may seem jarring, it's a positive indicator that work and culture are progressing without the need of an office. This will create opportunities to capture greater real estate savings and/or repurpose office space for philanthropic efforts, such as opening up an internship center for the local community.

Blueprints from companies openly sharing their transition to hybrid-remote

We believe it's useful for transitioning companies to see how others are embracing and making the shift to hybrid-remote structures. Below are examples of companies who are publicly and transparently sharing their journey, best practices, and lessons learned to guide others.

1. Dropbox - Virtual First Toolkit
1. Slack - A new guide for adapting to a radically different workplace
1. Hubspot - How we're building a hybrid company
1. Coinbase - Building a remote-first company: our biggest lessons so far
1. Herman Miller - The Future of Work: Looking Forward

Companies embracing hybrid-remote

COVID-19 created a wave of companies intentionally shifting to remote-first. For some organizations, unwinding all of their office space and becoming an all-remote organization is not practical. Many are announcing their plan to embrace some variation of hybrid-remote. This is not an exhaustive list, so we welcome additions and contributions.

- 1. HubSpot · The Future of Work at HubSpot: How We're Building a Hybrid Company
- 1. Dropbox · Dropbox goes Virtual First
- 1. Robinhood · Robinhood is a Remote First Company
- 1. Reddit · Evolving Reddit's Workforce
- 1. Figma · How work is changing at Figma
- 1. Coinbase · Post COVID-19, Coinbase will be a remote-first company
- 1. Shopify · Digital by default
- 1. Twitter · Where We Work
- 1. Slack · A new guide for adapting to a radically different workplace
- 1. Sike Insights · EQ & Remote Managers Report
- 1. Spotify · Distributed-First Is the Future of Work at Spotify
- 1. Grammarly · The Future of Work at Grammarly
- 1. Mailchimp · The Future of Work at Mailchimp
- 1. Adobe - The Future of Work at Adobe
- 1. Asana - Reuniting and Thriving in a Distributed World With Asana
- 1. LinkedIn - A Sneak Peek at LinkedIn's New Hybrid Workplace Plans
- 1. DoorDash - DoorDash's Hybrid Work Plan: Committing to Flexibility
- 1. Uber - Our Return to the Office
- 1. Cisco - Cisco Powers Hybrid Work
- 1. Intel - Creating a "Hybrid-First" Company
- 1. Lyft - We're Going Fully Flexible
- 1. Google - A Hybrid Approach to Work
- 1. Amazon - Amazon Updates Return-to-Office Guidance
- 1. Canva - Canva's Future of Work: Flexibility and Connection
- 1. Microsoft - The Philosophy and Practice of our Hybrid Workplace
- 1. Unilever - Our Future Workplace
- 1. Zoom - How Zoom is Approaching our Next Phase of Work
- 1. Deloitte - Transforming when, where, and how we work

Do hybrid-remote employees have a commute?

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Some hybrid-remote arrangements do involve regular commutes to the office, though not daily commutes. For example, a remote employee in a hybrid-remote organization may travel to an office one week each month for regularly scheduled in-person interactions, while working from a location of their choosing the rest of the month.

While this scenario may still be preferred over one where remote employees are not invited to visit in-person offices, it isn't quite as flexible as all-remote. There's still a commute involved, which can take the majority of a day in both directions for commutes involving flights.

Are there advantages to hybrid-remote?

Better work-life balance

Hybrid-remote employees can plan for more flexibility in their daily life (for kids, parents, friends, groceries, sports, deliveries).

Optimize when and where you work

A hybrid-remote schedule is often asynchronous, allowing an individual to choose their working hours based on when they are most productive.

They can also set up and decorate an office or workspace in whatever way works best for them.

And of course, a hybrid schedule allows more flexibility for traveling while working.

Reduce exposure to illness

Especially after the global pandemic, people are concerned about decreasing their exposure to germs from coworkers. Hybrid-remote allows employees to choose whether to work onsite or remotely, and empowers them to choose their exposure boundaries and limits.

Save on real estate expenses

Some hybrid-remote options allow employees to choose where they live. At any given time, they are free to relocate, be location independent, or even travel with other remote professionals.

Hire talent across the globe

Not only does hybrid remote allow organizations to hire the best talent on the planet, it also gives your employees the opportunity to network as they meet and work with people from many locations around the world, widening one's view of the world and creating opportunities to learn about new cultures.

Disadvantages to hybrid-remote

All things being equal, employees longing for additional freedom, autonomy, and workplace flexibility will likely view a hybrid-remote arrangement as superior to a colocated arrangement · one which requires a commute and an in-person presence on a daily basis.

Said another way, "some remote" is often viewed as superior to "no remote." Though far from ideal, it can be rationalized that fewer career opportunities, added judgement, and difficulties in bonding are prices worth paying to live and work where one wants.

There are considerations when accepting a role in a hybrid-remote company, and it's important to be mindful of these potential downsides.

1. Hybrid-remote employees may have less access to information. Unless you work for an employer that documents everything, you may be asked to handle your day-to-day duties with less information · and incomplete information · compared to in-person colleagues. Over time, this

can lead to more mistakes, confusion, frustration, and even underperformance.

1. Fewer career and development opportunities. Hybrid-remote employees who are out of sight may be passed over for promotions, advancement, and development opportunities. They may also have fewer opportunities to move horizontally within the organization, and less influence to create a new role to serve evolving business needs.

1. The feeling of being a satellite office. Hybrid-remote employees must put effort towards not being treated as less-than within the organization. It is important to surface relevant inquiries during the interview process as to how remote colleagues are onboarded, included, and perceived by others. Some employees may not be fazed by this treatment, but it can take a mental and emotional toll on others.

1. Managing guilt. It is not uncommon to hear remote workers express guilt if they work in a company which is primarily colocated. Their socializing involves colleagues who may complain about commutes, or express sadness due to an inability to attend a certain family function. There are inherent inequalities in this arrangement, requiring the remote employee to empathize with in-person colleagues despite not being required to endure the same commutes and inflexibility.

1. The burden of lobbying for remote. If an employee is brought on in a remote capacity, but this arrangement is not supported equally across teams and managers, a situation may arise where the remote employee is constantly justifying the perceived privilege of not being forced to commute into a physical office.

1. Determining whether remote is truly offered and supported. Many large companies will tolerate remote employees, but they will not openly advertise roles as remote, nor will they publicly admit that they support remote work. This creates an exhausting game of hide-and-seek when searching for roles, in addition to searching for remote-friendly managers and teams within such an organization.

1. Risk of being made an example of. It is possible for remote employees in a primarily colocated company to be asked questions like "So, how did you finagle a remote arrangement?" This places remote employees in a difficult situation. Either they choose to champion the cause of empowering even more colleagues to work remotely, potentially harming their reputation in the process, or they appear unhelpful by keeping the perceived perk to themselves.

1. Demands for overperformance. When you're a remote employee working with colleagues who endure long commutes each day, you may encounter pressure · however subtle · to deliver results beyond those expected of in-person team members. This stems from a toxic culture of envy, where colocated employees deduce that if they must endure inflexibility and commutes, remote colleagues must produce additional results as to not get off easier.

1. A culture built around the in-office experience. Companies that rely heavily on physical perks and in-office experiences to define their culture have a difficult time translating those experiences to their remote employees in a hybrid-remote setting. You'll often see these perks highlighted for talent acquisition and retention purposes. In practice, remote employees will inherently miss out on the full employee experience unless the culture is more intentionally and sustainably built.

1. Physiological stress linked to open-plan offices. Some hybrid-remote firms may require team members to work in open-plan office environments. Research published in 2021 by Cambridge University shows a "significant causal relationship between open-plan office noise and physiological stress." Working anywhere · home, office, etc. · can trigger stress if conditions are suboptimal, though all-remote generally provides greater flexibility to shift your workspace from home, co-working venues, offices, and nature to optimize for greater calm.

Overcoming the hybrid-remote model's problems

Clear communication is one of the best ways to overcome hybrid-remote challenges. GitLab's handbook captures everything an employee needs to know promoting autonomy and efficiency for communication, processes, and procedures.

Each department and team should set, share, and track both monthly and quarterly goals, or "objectives and key results" (OKRs). GitLab's OKRs are also clearly documented in our handbook for visibility across the company.

Our unique approach to documentation also helps with onboarding new team members by putting everything they need to know in one place.

Finally, we recommend developing an extensive onboarding template. Hosting a panel, like our GitLab 101, allows new hires to ask questions.

What does a hybrid-remote work schedule look like?

A lot goes into building an effective hybrid-remote schedule:

- Are there days your team has set meetings?
- When and where are you personally most productive?
- Will your work get done better/faster working face-to-face?

Some people choose set days or times to be in-office or be remote, just be sure to communicate your choices clearly to your team so they know when and where they can find you if needed.

Work how and when you are most productive

Some people work better with a consistent workday routine, while others find it best to ride their waves of peak productivity. Either way, design your work day and routine around your strengths understanding that different seasons, holidays, and family schedules may change this routine.

> "I think you need to throw the concept of 'nine to five' out the window and actively experiment to find what schedule lets you make the most of your time.

I often find the midday slump to be so real, so if I'm feeling this way I step away for a while and then come back for a few hours in the evening when I generally feel supercharged."

- Tanya Pazitny, Quality Engineering Manager

All-Remote Upgrade

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The movement from hybrid-remote to all-remote is defined at GitLab as an All-Remote Upgrade. For reference, in January 2020, 17% of new hires attending the CEO 101 call moved from a hybrid-remote model to all-remote at GitLab.

This highlights another reality: not all remote models are equal, nor do they create equality. All-remote is the purest form of remote work, where every individual is treated as a first-class team member.

Through GitLab's All-Remote Stories and the Remote Work GitLab Unfiltered playlist, you can learn more from GitLab team members on what all-remote has meant to them and how it has shaped their lives and communities.

Differences between all-remote and remote-first

In a remote-first organization, the default is remote. While there may be a company headquarters, or even an array of satellite offices, everything from how meetings are handled to onboarding new hires is structured through a remote lens.

Said another way, there is a culture of assuming that remote is the norm, not the exception, and processes are established to reinforce that.

If you're considering working for a remote-first company, consider asking the following.

1. Do you have a headquarters?
1. Does the executive team work remotely, or do they all congregate in the same physical space day-to-day?
1. Where and how are all-hands calls handled?
1. Are interviews and onboarding handled on-premise or via video call?
1. Do team members have hybrid calls, or does each person have their own equipment?
1. What procedures are in place to ensure that remote employees are granted learning and development and promotion opportunities?

It is possible to find remote-first companies with a healthy, understanding culture that works to support both colocated and remote colleagues. Prospective employees should do their own due diligence to make sure the requisite values are established and lived out.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Understanding a Hybrid-Remote Environment

Anyone can test their knowledge on Understanding a Hybrid-Remote Environment by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

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{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}
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Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/in-person.md

{style="max-width: 50%;"}</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 172 950 237" data-label="Text">
<p>Humans are social creatures, and research has shown that there is value in in-person interactions. While there are tremendous advantages to operating a 100% remote company, leaders should consider being intentional about planning in-person elements, even if they're optional for team members.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 255 435 271" data-label="Section-Header">
<h3>Bridging the gap during the pandemic</h3>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 287 925 320" data-label="Text">
<p>While the Covid-19 pandemic has impacted many teams' ability to gather in person, the guidance on this page can be used as a blueprint for your organization's future in-person interactions.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 336 950 420" data-label="Text">
<p>Small teams located in the same city or region may be able to still gather in person, but for an all-remote company where team members are distributed across many time zones, you'll need to lean on platforms like Zoom, Hopin, or Virbela to gather virtually in the meantime. It's important to maintain the purpose of these gatherings, and to be intentional and creative about continuing to bring the team together.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 436 905 503" data-label="Text">
<p>For example, at GitLab, we hosted our 2020 Contribute virtually. We used this time to take a break from our daily projects, celebrate the achievements of the team, and get to know one another better. By focusing this time on bonding rather than active work, we were able to boost engagement and invest in strengthening the relationships across the organization.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 519 879 553" data-label="Text">
<p>Between these larger gatherings, informal communication is another important element to maintain. We've curated a list of ways to approach this in our informal communication guide.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 568 357 586" data-label="Section-Header">
<h3>Benefits of remote meetings</h3>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 602 310 619" data-label="Section-Header">
<h4>Attendance is optional</h4>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 635 925 719" data-label="Text">
<p>GitLab has a meeting policy we like to call "No agenda, no attenda." Every work-related meeting has purpose, which is outlined a live doc agenda affixed to the calendar invite: here's a templated example you can copy and use in your organization. As an all-remote company, we do not look to a meeting by default; when they are necessary, we strive to make in-person attendance optional by enabling asynchronous contribution.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 735 313 752" data-label="Section-Header">
<h4>Meetings are recorded</h4>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 768 903 834" data-label="Text">
<p>Remote meetings can be recorded, especially when key individuals aren't able to join live. This allows team members to catch up on what transpired, adding context to notes that were taken during the meeting. Learn more about recording in Zoom in the Tips and Tricks section of GitLab's Handbook.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="120 851 200 867" data-label="Section-Header">
<h4>Inclusive</h4>
</div>
<div data-bbox="114 884 960 902" data-label="Text">
<p>Remote meetings that are accessible asynchronously encourage increased attendance because they</p>
</div>

remove time zone bias. Employees can view the meeting invite, agenda, and recording, and can contribute asynchronously as they are able.

Benefits of in-person meetings

If a live meeting is recorded and made available to others, many of the same benefits of remote meetings apply to in-person meetings as well. However, it's hard for technology to capture the non-verbals and camaraderie that inevitably happens in an in-person meeting, which sometimes falls flat online.

Synchronicity

Just as asynchronous participation is a benefit of remote meetings, there is a certain collaborative magic that can happen during an in-person meeting or retreat that is more difficult (though not impossible) to reproduce virtually. Often, the greatest value of being in a shared space is the ability to spin off ideas and smaller conversations and keep them going as new ideas arise.

Networking

On a virtual call, you're limited to viewing a certain number of faces at a time. In person, you potentially have an opportunity to connect with everyone in the room.

How to prepare for an in-person meeting

In-person meeting prep is similar to getting ready for a video call. In these situations, you should plan to:

1. Start and end on time

1. Build in social interactions and plan to get to know the people in your group

1. Have the meeting space prepared to support visual thinking and collaboration

1. Plan to document the complex discussions that will happen as often an in-person meeting is required because of its need for immediate back and forth conversation

1. Take notes to help retain and recall any important details

1. Document by writing down notes and next steps into the proper directory (Google Drive, Salesforce, etc.)

The importance of social interaction

We believe that in-person interactions are extremely important, especially in an all-remote culture. Remote workers have increased risk of experiencing loneliness or burnout.

One way to prevent loneliness and burnout are through relationship-building by prioritizing regular social interactions via informal communication throughout the workday, week, and month.

Informal communication enables friendships to form at work related to matters other than work. Those who feel they have genuine friends at work are more likely to enjoy their job, perform at a high level, feel invested in the company, and serve others within the organization.

Here, we value informal communication as a complement to in-person interactions and regularly

offer more than 20 different ways for team members to participate in social interactions!

Meetups

{{< youtube "hi2D0SeVnA" >}}

GitLab Commit Brooklyn 2019 recap reel.

Organizing customer and/or community meetups around the globe is a great way to ensure team members meet each other in person, while also providing business and branding benefits. Meetups serve as incubators for what could come next, and provide a safe space for feedback to flow. Not only do they allow customers to put a face to a company they are engaging with, but it creates opportunity for team members to travel and meet each other while supporting a company initiative.

In an all-remote setting, meetups have psychological benefits as well. While colocated companies may struggle to garner deep support from team members who must plan, execute, and attend a meetup, all-remote team members tend to view meetups as special opportunities to do something they aren't able to do on a daily basis: interact with colleagues in the same physical space.

Perception plays a major role in quality of execution. In colocated settings, team members are required to commute and spend much of their waking hours with colleagues in a shared space. This could make the notion of spending added time, likely outside of their normal working hours, seem more like a burden and less like a bonding opportunity.

Conversely, team members in an all-remote setting have precious few opportunities to see one another face-to-face. In turn, may be easier to rally support for meetups given the underlying perk of in-person bonding and networking.

Learn more about how GitLab organizes community events in the [GitLab Meetup Guide](#).

Conferences

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{{% card footer="GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij and General Catalyst Managing Director Kyle Doherty kick off Making Remote Work. Photo by Slava Blazer Photography" %}}}

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It is common for colocated companies to send a lean contingent to work-related conferences, which is rational given the relative high costs involved. In colocated settings, work conferences add marginal bonding benefit given that attendees already spend a significant amount of time together in a shared physical office.

In remote-first and all-remote settings, the value proposition is drastically different. Conferences serve as an opportunity to send a team of colleagues to not only execute on business objectives, but also to spend time bonding with one another as humans.

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{{% card footer="Colleagues together at GitLab Commit London 2019" %}}

{{% /card %}}

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Consider supporting team members who wish to arrive early or stay late in order to spend time getting to know colleagues on a face-to-face basis, but be mindful not to judge or penalize those who opt out. Family commitments and personal preference should be honored. Choosing not to arrive early or stay late at a conference for bonding should not be viewed as indifference toward